

Lecture 3:

Marx, Weber, Durkheim

Course: Introduction to Human Sciences

Karl Marx

(but also Fredrick Engels)

SOCIAL FORMATION

*“A social formation refers to a society (a social structure at any level such as a nation, city, business, university, or even a family) with all its complexities, as it is **historically constituted**. It includes all the internal **contradictions** that exist in a society, all emerging and disappearing tendencies in the economy and superstructure, in the social relationships that comprise these.”*

- Stratification is result of specific historical processes.
- Stratification is conflict-ridden, and thus has the inherent potential to change shape.

Primitive communism ---- Feudalism -----
Capitalism ----- Socialism ----- Communism

The Marxist Approach

MAIN IDEAS:

Materialism

- “According to the materialistic conception, the determining factor is, in the final instance, the production and reproduction of the immediate essentials of life.” ~ Fredrick Engels

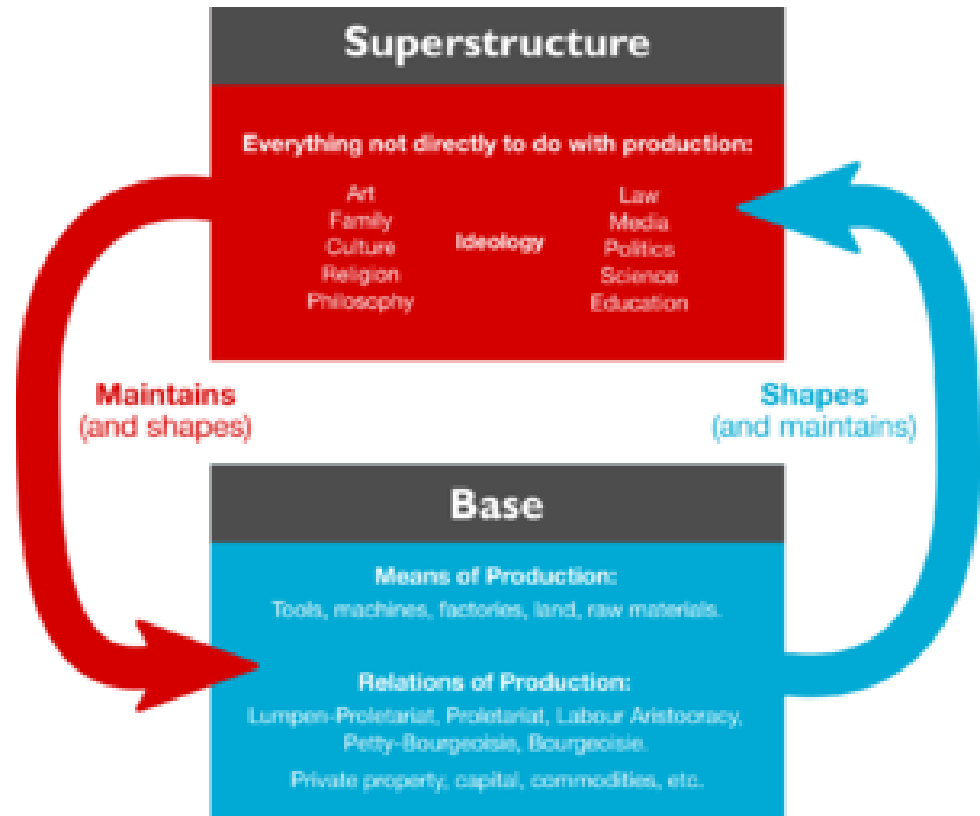
Marx asks:

- What are the ‘productive forces’? Labour, as well as means of production (equipments, buildings, land, technologies, information etc...).
- What the social relations of production? Ownership patterns, patterns of power and control...

TOGETHER, they make up the ‘MODES OF PRODUCTION’.

The Marxist Approach

- Family structure is linked to form of property ownership
 - Which itself is linked to the mode and relations of production
- Property ownership is linked to form of State
 - Clear causal link between the smallest social unit (emotional base of society) with social relations and State form



**This moves in a spiral pattern.
The base is generally dominant.**

Karl Marx

(but also Fredrick Engels)

ALIENATION

- Special feature of capitalist society
- Humans alienated from product of their own labour
- Creates alienation between humans
- Alienation from self
- Alienation from nature
- Affects culture and family

Émile Durkheim

- Established sociology as an academic discipline
- Drew on Auguste Comte
- Wanted to understand how society sustains itself; how it maintains its coherence and integrity
- Scientific methods for study of society
 - Identify and define different parts of society by their function in maintaining social order
- Society is more than a sum of its parts
 - Society is formed of individuals but each person can be seen as an individual only when society is formed

What IS a Social Fact?

A social fact is any way of acting, whether fixed or not, capable of exerting over the individual an external constraint

– Durkheim

- Include social institutions and social activities. Statuses, roles, laws, beliefs.
- External to every individual.
- Coercive.

Social facts CANNOT be explained by reducing them to the level of the individual.

Examples: Divorce rate, economic growth rate, population distribution, urbanization, religious structures, caste divisions.

Explaining Cultural Change

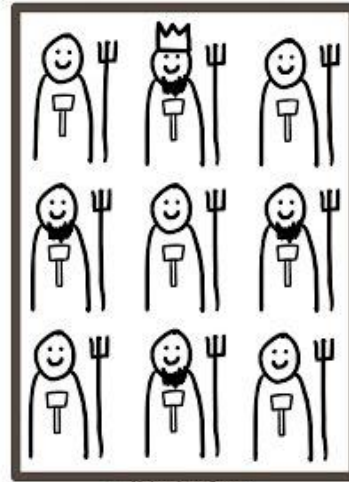
“Old order is being swept away...loss of security and predictability”

- ❑ Pre-industrial societies: Simple, unsegmented, homogenous clans. MECHANICAL solidarity based on religious beliefs, “collective consensus/conscience”, individuals SIMILAR in behavior/moral respects.

- ❑ Western industrialization: BREAKDOWN of collective conscience.

WHAT holds society together?

mechanical solidarity
(pre-modern)



solidarity from
collective conscience

organic solidarity
(modern)



solidarity from
inter-dependence

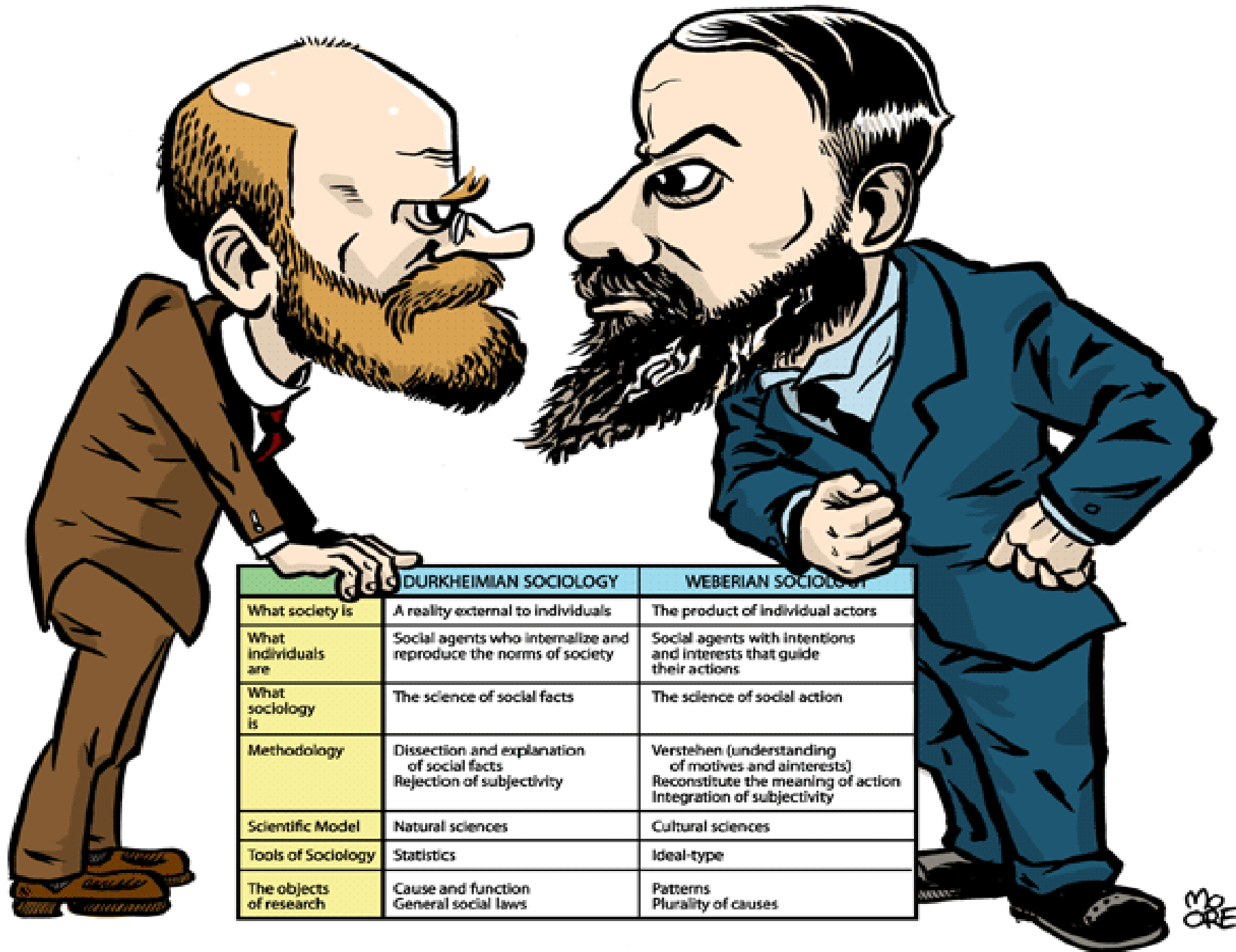
Explaining Cultural Change

ROOTS of EVOLUTIONALISM:

- ❑ Western industrialization: BREAKDOWN of collective conscience. DIVISION of LABOUR → Increasing individualism, heterogeneity, interdependence
- ❑ NEW MORAL ORDER: Social solidarity was ORGANIC rather than MECHANICAL.
- ❑ BUT, the move from mechanical to organic solidarity was NOT AUTOMATIC. ABNORMALITIES arose.
- ❑ ANOMIE: Rootlessness, lack of regulation, lack of moral discipline.
- ❑ NEED to develop moral code/order based on occupational associations, which would provide sense of belonging/solidarity/mutual assistance.

Max Weber

- Extended Marx and Durkheim in engagement and contestation
- Focus on Capitalism and its society
- Ideal-type
- Method of identifying actions and interpreting their meaning
- Finding patterns and locating subjectivity



	DURKHEIMIAN SOCIOLOGY	WEBERIAN SOCIOLOGY
What society is	A reality external to individuals	The product of individual actors
What individuals are	Social agents who internalize and reproduce the norms of society	Social agents with intentions and interests that guide their actions
What sociology is	The science of social facts	The science of social action
Methodology	Dissection and explanation of social facts Rejection of subjectivity	Verstehen (understanding of motives and ainterests) Reconstitute the meaning of action Integration of subjectivity
Scientific Model	Natural sciences	Cultural sciences
Tools of Sociology	Statistics	Ideal-type
The objects of research	Cause and function General social laws	Patterns Plurality of causes

Weberian Approach

Weber founded 'interpretive' sociology. Argued that study of social action should not be purely empirical. It should try and understand ('interpret') the *meanings* and *purposes* that individuals attach to their actions. *Rejected* monocausality.

INTERPRETATIVE SOCIOLOGY

- There is NO objectively "correct" meaning. Meaning depends on Context and Subjectivity, unlike empirical 'truth'.
- The dividing line between 'objective' (understandable) and 'subjective' (non-understandable) action is hazy. They are bound up together.
- 'Motives' have to be identified.

The Weberian Approach

“In the great majority of cases actual action goes on in a state of inarticulate half-consciousness or actual unconsciousness of its subjective meaning. The actor is more likely to “be aware” of it in a vague sense than he is to “know” what he is doing or to explicitly self-conscious about it. In most cases his action is governed by impulse or habit. Only occasionally and, in the uniform action of large numbers, often only in the case of a few individuals, is the subjective meaning of the action, whether rational or irrational, brought clearly into consciousness. The ideal type of meaningful action where the meaning is fully conscious and explicit is a marginal case...”

– Max Weber

The Weberian Approach

Types of social action:

- *Instrumentally rational*: Expects/anticipates behavior of others, and acts accordingly. 'Rational', logical, towards one's goals.
- *Value rational*: Believes and acts upon a value for religious, ethical, aesthetic reason. Even if success is not anticipated.
- *Emotional*: Follows feelings and emotions.
- *Traditional*: Follows deeply ingrained habits.

Weber: These are PATTERNS in behavior. Modern society is moving towards more 'instrumental rational' behavior, in both personal and social spheres.

Conscious	Unconscious
Functional rational (calculating)	Emotional (spontaneous)
Substantial rational (from principles)	Traditional (habitual)

Max Weber

RATIONALITY

- Modern society marked by universalisation of rationality
- Both individual and social actions
- Personal
 - rational efforts aimed at achieving economic gain
- Social
 - Bureaucracy (rational – legal)
 - instrumental rational action

Behaviour in modern societies comes to be dictated more by goal-oriented rationality and less and less by tradition, values or emotions. Mechanisation and division of labour are also other features of this process of rationalisation.

Max Weber

BUREAUCRACY

- Division of labour with chains of command
- Duties assigned and strictly demarcated
- Impersonal authority
- Abstract rules
- Politically neutral

“BUREAUCRATIC ADMINISTRATION MEANS FUNDAMENTALLY
DOMINATION THROUGH KNOWLEDGE”

Max Weber

Bureaucracy “...results is the development of an iron cage,
A technically ordered, rigid, dehumanised society.”

specialists without
spirit, sensualists
without heart; this
nullity imagines that it
has attained a level of
civilization never before
achieved.

Max Weber

Videos

- Karl Marx's idea of alienation
<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=PZ4VzhluKCQ&feature=youtu.be>
- Emile Durkheim's idea of Social Fact
<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=uBKAAmXY2g>
- Max Weber's idea of religion as a source of capitalism
<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=tbcClUEFG3c>